



Episode 173: The Special Foods for the Night(s) of Rosh Hashanah

By Morris Arking

Dedicated in memory of Elliot Setton A"H By his wife and children

One of the most notable customs of Rosh HaShanah are the special fruits and vegetables that we eat on the first night, and in some households on both nights of Rosh HaShanah. Hakham Yisshaq Shehebar A"H was quoted in Derekh Eress as specifying that the custom in Halab was to serve these fruits and vegetables only on the first night of the holiday. This opinion is also found in the Kaf HaHayyim (Sofer) 583:7. Furthermore it was customary in most households to eat these food items after HaMossi, but some had the custom to serve them right after Qiddush prior to making Netilat Yadayim (Derekh Eress pgs.114, 187).

The origin of this custom is the Gemara. It is recorded in Masekhet Horayot (12a) and in Masekhet K'retot (6a). Masekhet Horayot writes that one should see these vegetables/fruit, but in Masekhet K'retot it says that one should eat them. In Shulhan 'Arukh Maran wrote that one should eat them (OH 583:1) The Gemara only lists five foods; gourd, black-eyed peas, leek, Swiss chard and dates. In Shulhan 'Arukh Maran added the head of sheep based on the writings of the Mordekhi in Masekhet Yoma, quoting the Geonim (see the Bet Yosef OH 583 in the last paragraph that begins Katub). However Maran omitted the sweet apple in honey which is recorded by the Tur (OH 583), and the pomegranate which Maran mentioned in the Bet Yosef in the name of the Abudarham (14th century Spain). Still in all, many later middle-eastern Rabbis included both the apple and the pomegranate on their list of fruits and vegetables for the night(s) of Rosh HaShanah. Both the apple and the pomegranate are found on the lists of H Abraham Hamway in his Mahzor Bet Din (19th century Halab), the Ben Ish Hai (Nissabim 1:4), the Kaf HaHayyim (Sofer-OH 583:25), H Yisshaq Shehebar (20th century Halab/Argentina-see Derekh Eress pg 187) and H Obadyah Yosef (Hazon 'Obadyah-Yamim Noraim pg. 97 quoting the Ben Ish Hai) . And this is what's found in our community Mahzor, Shelom Yerushalayim which is based on an earlier Mahzor known as Zekhor L'Abraham.

When checking all of these sources I noticed that each source presents the list of fruits and vegetables in a different order. One of the issues is whether to begin with the dates or the apples. According to Halakhah we should have the dates before the other fruits since when one has several fruits in front of him he should recite Bore' P'ri Ha'Ess on a fruit from the seven species associated with the land of Israel. In our case the date takes precedence over the apple, and even over the pomegranate because of its position in the verse in the Torah that lists the seven species. However, H. Abraham Hamway, the Keter Shem Tob, the Mahzor Zekhor L'Abraham and subsequently the Mahzor Shelom Yerushalayim all begin with the apple. The custom of having an apple with these fruits and vegetables originated with the Ashkenazim, as specified by the Tur (OH 583), and their custom was to have the apple first. They began with an apple dipped in honey in order to start the year with something sweet.

How could they give the apple precedence over the date? The Kaf HaHayyim (Sofer) addresses this question (OH 583:13) and he writes that they would bring out the apple first before the dates. Since the dates were not on the table when they were eating the apple they recited Bore' P'ri Ha'Ess on the apple. Others ate the honey dipped apple on a piece of bread in order to avoid reciting Ha'Ess on the apple. Then they could still recite Ha'Ess on the date when they ate it afterwards. This Ashkenazic custom was adopted by middle-eastern Jews because of its' Qabbalistic significance. The apple signifies the "Haqal Tapuhin Qaddishin" (A Field of Holy Apples) which is a Qabbalistic expression that refers to the Divine Presence (Bet Din 29b:19, Keter Shem Tob 6 pg 97). Since the apple represents the Divine Presence it is appropriate to begin with the apple. There are some Halabi families that begin with the dates (as recorded by H. Yisshaq Shehebar- Derekh Eress pg. 187), but others that begin with the apple (recorded by H. Abraham Hamway-Bet Din pg 29b) H. Abraham Hamway quoted several opinions with regards to the B'rakhah on the apple, including reciting Ha'Ess on the pomegranate after Qiddush (before Netilat Yadayim), covering the apple and the date that would be served after HaMossi. Still in all the date should precede the pomegranate, so perhaps reciting Ha'Ess on an olive before HaMossi is a more preferable option. And then you would not recite Ha'Ess again after HaMossi.

Although the original Ashkenazic custom was to dip the apple in honey, many middle-eastern Jews use white sugar instead. Qabbalistically, sugar represents Hesed (kindness) as opposed to honey that represents Geburah (bravery). Since Hesed is more appropriate for the day of judgement, sugar is preferred (Kaf HaHayyim (Sofer) quoting Y'feh L'Leb 3:1) Furthermore it is also customary to dip the bread in sugar instead of salt on Rosh HaShanah (Bet Din 27b). Some individuals had the custom to dip the bread in salt prior to dipping it in sugar (or honey), however the custom of the majority is to dip the bread in sugar only (Customs of Aram Soba-Halab-H. Yosef

'Abadi Sha'yo pg 74:4). H. Abraham Hamway supported this custom when he wrote that sugar is comparable to salt, and some say that it may be used instead of salt when offering a sacrifice. And so he concluded, "And if so, Yafeh Minhagam Shel Yisrael (the Jewish custom is appropriate) to dip in sugar on Rosh HaShanah instead of salt".(Bet Din 27b)

It is also customary to recite a short prayer (Yehi Rasson) upon eating each fruit/vegetable. (Shulhan 'Arukh 583:1, based on Rab Hai Gaon) Many have the custom to recite the Yehi Rasson prior to eating each item (and before Bore' P'ri Ha'Ess when eating the first fruit), as found in our Mahzor Shelom Yerushalayim (pg. 107). However according to H Yisshaq Shehebar, in Halab it was customary to recite the Yehi Rasson after tasting each food (Derekh Eress pg. 187). May we all merit a year of health, happiness and prosperity and the rebuilding of the Bet HaMiqdash with the coming of the Mashiah!!